their second front, and they are ours” – premised on “a geopolitical community of interest” between India and the Soviet Union “with respect to China” fructified during the 1971 war.[74]

Hedging in the post–Cold War era

The third distinct period in India’s policy towards China was initiated after external balancing ceased to be a component in India’s China policy when the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991. Although India and Russia renewed the Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation in 1993 for a further period of 20 years and averred that it was “a continuation” of the previous treaty, they significantly diluted the key military provisions contained in the 1971 version. In the 1971 version, India and the Soviet Union had categorically stated that they would not participate in a military alliance directed against each other. But in the 1993 version, they only committed themselves not to take actions that might “pose a threat or impair the security of the other.” And, in contrast to their previous commitment to undertake consultations if one of them came under attack, they now limited themselves to consulting and coordinating positions in the event of “a threat to peace or breach of peace.”[75] These provisions were further diluted in the year 2000, when India and Russia opted to replace the 1993 Treaty with the declaration of a strategic partnership. In the process, they altogether dropped the provision on undertaking consultations in the event of a threat to or breach of peace. Further, while retaining the commitment to maintain military neutrality towards one another, they explicitly stated that their partnership “is not directed against any other State or group of States, and does not seek to create a military-